

The last couple of months have seen a fair amount of movement on the alternative OS front, for the want of simplicity and ease of use. Google pushed Android, as is, on certain AIOs recently and HP was leading that march. But, a much more refined alternative to Windows and Mac OS X is the new Chrome OS from Google. All laptops that come pre-loaded with Chrome OS are branded as Chromebooks, irrespective of brand or model. Currently, Acer, Samsung and HP are making some Chromebooks but surely, more laptop makers will join in in due course of time with a wider range of products.

But, it is more a case of expectation, to see how Chrome, as an operating system, works in a world where people have been mostly using Windows or Mac OS X for productivity and home / home-office use. But, for anyone who is looking to shift, do keep this in mind – it will be a major change, in some regards.

Usability, from the GO!

If you had chided Microsoft for the lack of the start button in Windows 8, this OS will possibly invite more snorts of derision. But then again, the purpose and the method of achieving the same purpose are completely different. And that is the learning curve with Chrome. Sign into your Google account, and what awaits you is the traditional desktop, but with a difference. On the taskbar (called Shelf, in this case) are the icons for Chrome browser, Gmail, Google Search, Google Docs and You Tube. If you use an Android phone, you will immediately recognize an icon very similar to the one that takes you to the app drawer. This is where the “apps” sit – stuff like the file manager, Tweet Deck or anything else that you may have downloaded.

For starters, and for all purposes, most of the stuff will run in the Chrome web browser. Too much Chrome branding to get confused with,



Not a lot is different from a user interface perspective

but bear with us! The base is the Chrome OS, while the quintessential window to the world of the Internets is the Chrome browser. You can download apps on the Chromebook, but they will almost always be web based versions.